

Software Engineering

CE2006/CZ2006

Software Processes

Topics covered

- ✧ Software process models
- ✧ Process activities

The software process

- ✧ A structured set of activities required to develop a software system.
- ✧ Many different software processes but all involve:
 - Specification – defining what the system should do;
 - Design and implementation – defining the organization of the system and implementing the system;
 - Validation – checking that it does what the customer wants;
 - Evolution – changing the system in response to changing customer needs.
- ✧ A software process model is an abstract representation of a process. It presents a description of a process from some particular perspective.

Software process descriptions

- ✧ When we describe and discuss processes, we usually talk about the activities in these processes such as specifying a data model, designing a user interface, etc. and the ordering of these activities.
- ✧ Process descriptions may also include:
 - Products, which are the outcomes of a process activity;
 - Roles, which reflect the responsibilities of the people involved in the process;
 - Pre- and post-conditions, which are statements that are true before and after a process activity has been enacted or a product produced.

Plan-driven and agile processes

- ✧ Plan-driven processes are processes where all of the process activities are planned in advance and progress is measured against this plan.
- ✧ In agile processes, planning is incremental and it is easier to change the process to reflect changing customer requirements.
- ✧ In practice, most practical processes include elements of both plan-driven and agile approaches.
- ✧ There are no right or wrong software processes.

Software process models

Software process models

✧ The waterfall model

- Plan-driven model. Separate and distinct phases of specification and development.

✧ Incremental development

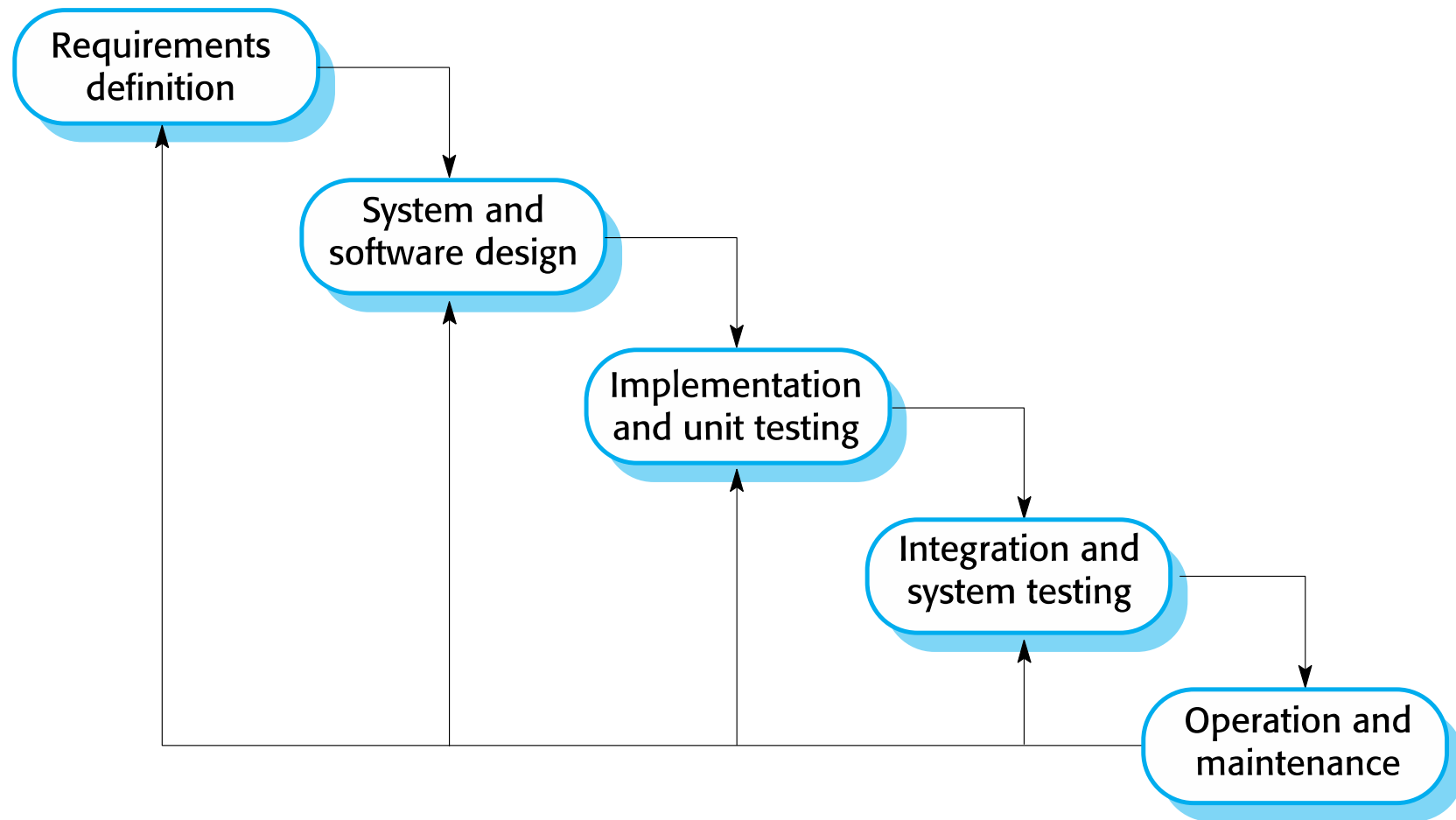
- Specification, development and validation are interleaved. May be plan-driven or agile.

✧ Integration and configuration

- The system is assembled from existing configurable components. May be plan-driven or agile.

✧ In practice, most large systems are developed using a process that incorporates elements from all of these models.

The waterfall model



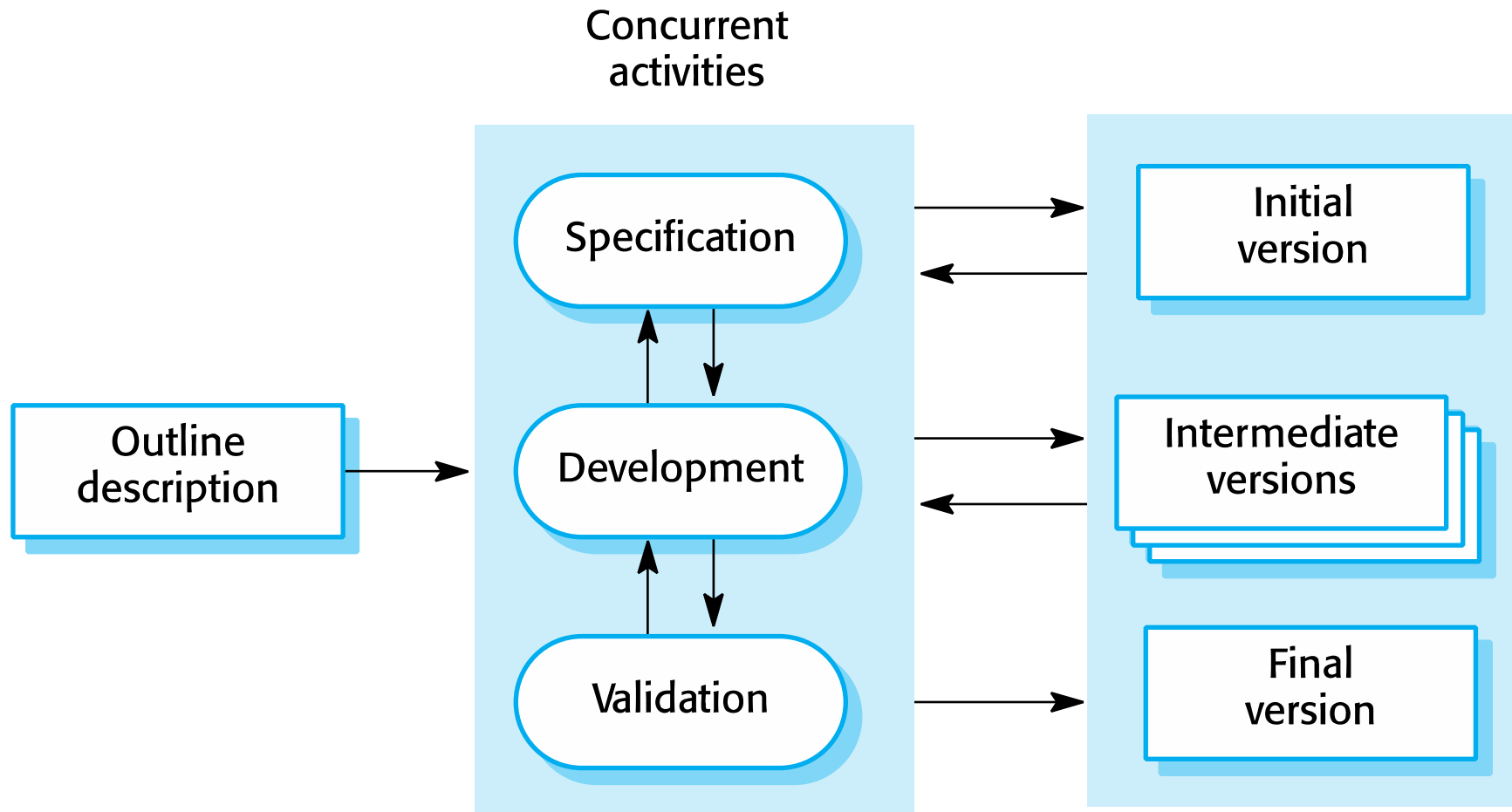
Waterfall model phases

- ✧ There are separate identified phases in the waterfall model:
 - Requirements analysis and definition
 - System and software design
 - Implementation and unit testing
 - Integration and system testing
 - Operation and maintenance
- ✧ The main drawback of the waterfall model is the difficulty of accommodating change after the process is underway. In principle, a phase has to be complete before moving onto the next phase.

Waterfall model problems

- ✧ Inflexible partitioning of the project into distinct stages makes it difficult to respond to changing customer requirements.
 - Therefore, this model is only appropriate when the requirements are well-understood and changes will be fairly limited during the design process.
 - Few business systems have stable requirements.
- ✧ The waterfall model is mostly used for large systems engineering projects where a system is developed at several sites.
 - In those circumstances, the plan-driven nature of the waterfall model helps coordinate the work.

Incremental development



Incremental development benefits

- ✧ The cost of accommodating changing customer requirements is reduced.
 - The amount of analysis and documentation that has to be redone is much less than is required with the waterfall model.
- ✧ It is easier to get customer feedback on the development work that has been done.
 - Customers can comment on demonstrations of the software and see how much has been implemented.
- ✧ More rapid delivery and deployment of useful software to the customer is possible.
 - Customers are able to use and gain value from the software earlier than is possible with a waterfall process.

Incremental development problems

✧ The process is not visible.

- Managers need regular deliverables to measure progress. If systems are developed quickly, it is not cost-effective to produce documents that reflect every version of the system.

✧ System structure tends to degrade as new increments are added.

- Unless time and money is spent on refactoring to improve the software, regular change tends to corrupt its structure. Incorporating further software changes becomes increasingly difficult and costly.

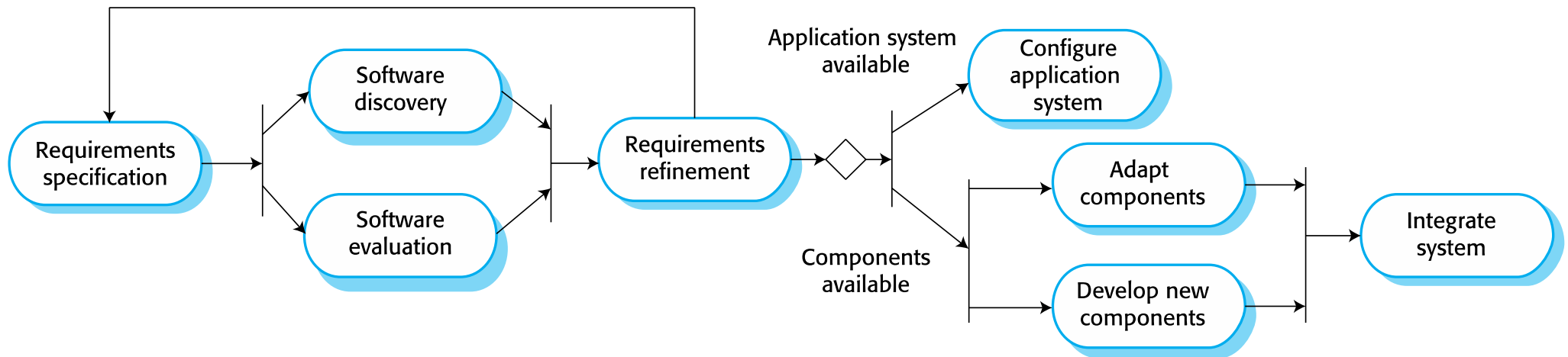
Integration and configuration

- ✧ Based on software reuse where systems are integrated from existing components or application systems (sometimes called COTS -Commercial-off-the-shelf) systems).
- ✧ Reused elements may be configured to adapt their behaviour and functionality to a user's requirements
- ✧ Reuse is now the standard approach for building many types of business system

Types of reusable software

- ✧ Stand-alone application systems (sometimes called COTS) that are configured for use in a particular environment.
- ✧ Collections of objects that are developed as a package to be integrated with a component framework such as .NET or J2EE.
- ✧ Web services that are developed according to service standards and which are available for remote invocation.

Reuse-oriented software engineering



Key process stages

- ✧ Requirements specification
- ✧ Software discovery and evaluation
- ✧ Requirements refinement
- ✧ Application system configuration
- ✧ Component adaptation and integration

Advantages and disadvantages

- ✧ Reduced costs and risks as less software is developed from scratch
- ✧ Faster delivery and deployment of system
- ✧ But requirements compromises are inevitable so system may not meet real needs of users
- ✧ Loss of control over evolution of reused system elements

Process activities

- ✧ Real software processes are inter-leaved sequences of technical, collaborative and managerial activities with the overall goal of specifying, designing, implementing and testing a software system.
- ✧ The four basic process activities of specification, development, validation and evolution are organized differently in different development processes.
- ✧ For example, in the waterfall model, they are organized in sequence, whereas in incremental development they are interleaved.

Key points

- ✧ Software processes are the activities involved in producing a software system. Software process models are abstract representations of these processes.
- ✧ General process models describe the organization of software processes.
 - Examples of these general models include the 'waterfall' model, incremental development, and reuse-oriented development.
- ✧ Requirements engineering is the process of developing a software specification.

Key points

- ✧ Design and implementation processes are concerned with transforming a requirements specification into an executable software system.
- ✧ Software validation is the process of checking that the system conforms to its specification and that it meets the real needs of the users of the system.
- ✧ Software evolution takes place when you change existing software systems to meet new requirements. The software must evolve to remain useful.